

Incident Alert 0004. TLP CLEAR.		Date	Breakout Scale
Title	IT – Salvini’s electoral campaign uses non-watermarked AI images	02/06/2024	3

Summary

- MEP candidate Matteo Salvini posted 6 AI-generated, non-watermarked images on X and Facebook, going against the transparency commitments of his European Political party, ID.
- The posts are part of Salvini’s “More Italy, less Europe” Italian electoral campaign and promote divisive narratives targeting the EU.
- The posts reached a high level of engagement. Salvini’s Facebook page ran one ad which reached more than 2 million people.

Incident – When, Who did what, to say what, to whom, why?

Between 22 and 30 May 2024, Matteo Salvini (MEP candidate, head of the Italian “Lega” party and Italian Minister for Transport and Infrastructures) created 6 posts ([1](#), [2](#), [3](#), [4](#), [5](#), [6](#)) using allegedly non-watermarked AI-generated images on his personal X account. These posts were part of his “More Italy, less Europe” electoral campaign.

Using non-watermarked AI images in against commitment 3.b of the 2024 European Parliament Elections Code of Conduct ([7](#)), a voluntary, non-binding agreement signed by all European Groups, including ID (Lega’s EP group). The Code applies only to European political parties and signatory member parties, which do not include Lega. However, it is important to flag when national parties fall below the transparency commitments of their own group. This should provide evidence on why it is important to foresee stronger oversight or mandatory transparency measures for national parties in for future EU elections.

Salvini’s Facebook page did not repost the images but ran one ad with one of the images ([8](#)) targeting Italian voters. Except for the ad, the AI generated images were only posted on Salvini’s personal X account. They were not posted by the Lega official accounts, except for one of Salvini’s tweets being reposted by the Lega X account.

Narrative

Meta narrative: The EU is against traditional values and products.

Sub-narratives: The EU is complicit in the Muslim “Great Replacement” ([9](#), [10](#)), the EU has untransparent governance ([11](#)), the EU is against Italian food products and farmers ([12](#), [13](#)), the EU is against the traditional family ([14](#))

Impact

Reach: The posts on X achieved 4869 Comments, 2475 Retweets, 8992 Likes and 161 saves. The Facebook ad reached more than 2 million people.

Key Objectives and Behaviours (DISARM Red Framework)

Objective: Divide - Create conflict between subgroups, to widen divisions in a community

Cultivate Support for Initiative - fortify the public backing for Salvini’s electoral campaign and ideas.

- Develop AI generated images (deep-fakes) – creation of allegedly 6 AI generated images, non-watermarked or unlabelled.
- Deliver ads – one Facebook as with the likely AI generated image.

Recommendations

- Flag to the Cabinet of Commissioner Jourova.
- Highlight problematic behaviour publicly.

Report	Topic	Evidence	Authors	Content type	Platforms
N/A	Islam, Transphobia,	Evidence Sheet	(Anonymous)	X posts, Facebook ad	X, Facebook
	Nationalism, AI		Alliance4Europe		